

Report Part Title: Conclusion

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Conclusion

After Israel withdrew from South Lebanon, Hizbollah was placed in an unfamiliar situation in which its freedom to maneuver in the region was drastically curtailed. The organization that was founded eighteen years earlier in response to the Israeli invasion of Lebanon suddenly discovered that it was almost completely denied its main area of military activity, namely, South Lebanon. Since then, Hizbollah has limited its official initiated military activity against Israel to the Shab'a Farms sector, where it carefully punctuates its operations with intervals of several months.

While Hizbollah did not entirely arrest its activity on Israel's northern border, it has increased its involvement in the Israeli-Palestinian confrontation that erupted as the al-Aqsa Intifada in September 2000, four months after Israel's unilateral withdrawal from the security zone in South Lebanon. More generally, since the withdrawal, Hizbollah refrained from extensive military operations while expanding its intelligence activity inside Israel and striving to infiltrate Israel's Arab population. For example, during the General Security Service investigation of Amr Ghazal, a resident of the Galilee who was arrested in September 2002 on suspicion of aiding Hizbollah, it was discovered that the cell phone on the body of one of the terrorists who had carried out the Matzuva attack was one of several smuggled into Lebanon by Ghazal himself. Additional interrogations have disclosed other Israeli Arabs recruited by the organization while they were visiting Jordan.

Notwithstanding this increased activity, a distinct gap exists between the assessments and concerns voiced in Israel in the months preceding the IDF withdrawal – the same reservations that effectively delayed the withdrawal for years – and the extent of their realization, although Israeli intelligence estimates predicted various Hizbollah operational patterns that did in fact materialize. The divide between the estimates and their realization thus seems to be a quantitative one, or more precisely, a matter of proportion. Although Hizbollah enjoys wide independence and freedom of maneuver, it is nonetheless limited by the interests of its strategic environment. Israel's assessment of the imperatives under which Hizbollah's operates, i.e., varying

exigencies and interests that motivate or restrain Hizbollah's activity, seems to have been flawed.

From many points of view, the integration of these interests created a framework of pressures for Hizbollah. For example, Hizbollah maintains close operational coordination with Palestinian organizations in Lebanon, and it was this cooperation, according to Israeli intelligence, that produced the Matzuva attack in March 2002. However, the political reality in Lebanon – staunch opposition to all Palestinian activity against Israel emanating from within the country – has thus far made this strike a one-time incident. Of course there is no guarantee that Hizbollah will not dispatch another Palestinian suicide team from Lebanon into Israel – Israel has indeed received several intelligence warnings of Matzuva-style attacks – but as long as a system of restraints, checks, and balances is brought to bear on Hizbollah, as it has since May 2000, then its current lines of activity are not expected to deviate much. The balance of pressures could be upset in the future, but this is not inevitable.

Whatever changes take place in the nature and limitations of Hizbollah activity, they will be determined by developments in relevant arenas – Lebanon, Syria, Israel, the Palestinian territories, Iran, and the United States war against terror. Likewise, US operations in Iraq will have serious ramifications for the region and also Hizbollah. The fate of the US presence and influence in Iraq could determine the regional players' maneuverability. The ouster of Saddam Hussein put an end to fourteen decades of Sunni control of the country, and this may have an effect on non-Sunni forces in the Middle East. Yet overall, as long as Syria and Lebanon perceive a direct military confrontation with Israel as a danger to be avoided, Hizbollah will have to take this into account. As long as Lebanon needs to attract investments from wealthy countries and international organizations in order to improve its economic distress – Lebanon's foreign debt has skyrocketed to more than \$30 billion and requires long-term management – Hizbollah will have to consider this exigency as well.

According to reliable data, over the last years, Iran has encouraged Hizbollah to continue the struggle against Israel and at the same time has acted as a restraining influence on the organization. The statements uttered by Iranian Foreign Minister Kamal Kharazi in April 2002 evoked surprise and confusion in the Israeli intelligence community, as well as among Hizbollah leaders. At the height of Hizbollah's escalation on Mt. Dov, the most serious military activity since Israel's withdrawal, Kharazi landed in Beirut and announced that Israel should not be handed a pretext for attacking its northern neighbors. In May 2003 there was a new Iranian call for restraint, this time from President Muhammad Khatami while on a visit to Lebanon. Addressing tens of thousands, Khatami emphasized that "under the difficult circumstances currently

afflicting the region, we understand that American pressures on Syria and Lebanon have increased. We are acutely aware that Israel must not be offered new pretexts for enlisting American power to advance its interests. We have no desire to contribute to an escalation of regional tensions."¹

It appears, then, that in Tehran too there are people who realize that a major escalation between Israel and its neighbors goes against Iranian interests, just as there are some voices in Iran that dare to advocate publicly pragmatic positions towards Israel, such as supporting its right to exist alongside a Palestinian state. The position that Kharazi expressed in Beirut, which earned both scathing criticism and praise in the Iranian media, emanated from several platforms. First, elements exist in Iran that are displeased with their country's image as a warmonger, especially when this image exposes Iran to international danger. Furthermore, in a head-on clash between Israel and Syria, the latter, Iran's ally, is expected to emerge the loser, and Hizbollah too would be exposed to danger if it caused Israel to exact from Lebanon a price for the organization's continued provocations.

On the other hand, as long as Israel continues to be embroiled in an ongoing confrontation with the Palestinians, Hizbollah will probably enjoy relatively easier conditions for operating against Israel on the northern border, as well as in the Palestinian arena and even within Israel itself. The al-Aqsa Intifada, which has inflamed the Israeli-Palestinian arena, has rendered not only Israel more vulnerable, but also the Middle East more sensitive and unstable than in the past. This state of affairs has poisoned the air between Israel and its neighbors, and strengthened Hizbollah's ability to influence the Arab-Israeli conflict and restore its domestic relevancy as an armed organization.

Hizbollah could also confront a different reality with relative ease, a situation whereby Israel posed a critical threat to the Shiite organization, Lebanon, or Syria. In his book, Qasim contends that should Israel launch an aggressive strike against Lebanon, the fault would lie with Israel and not with Hizbollah's provocation. From Israel's point of view, certainly the opposite situation is preferred: that Hizbollah would be perceived in Lebanon and the world as the provocateur and aggressor.

A more positive situation, in which calm settles over the Palestinian arena and, later perhaps, a political arrangement is worked out between Israel, Syria, and Lebanon, would be a seminal threat to Hizbollah's existence as an independent military organization. From Hizbollah's point of view, the challenge of peace would be the supreme of challenges. The more that the region inches forward in the direction of pacification, political processes, and permanent arrangements, the more Hizbollah will be forced to adapt itself to this reality, even if repudiating it ideologically.

At the same time, Hizbollah's organizational and social status, which has become rooted in Lebanese society and the national political arena, cannot be ignored. The fundamental link between Hizbollah and its constituency through the various forms of assistance it extends to a wide public is Hizbollah's basis for adapting to future developments, beginning with a marked reduction in its military activity against Israel and culminating in political arrangements between Israel and its neighbors. Hizbollah's social and organizational infrastructure will ensure its organizational survival in the long run. A stockpile of thousands of rockets and the armed fighters are not only a deterrent against Israel but also a force that broadcasts the message to the Lebanese environment that Hizbollah is here to stay – and that one day, as a token gesture, it might agree to be disarmed. Naturally, as the outstanding representative of the Shiite community, Hizbollah would expect compensation for such a gesture. It is also possible that it will be fully integrated into the official Lebanese establishment.

The loss of the main arena of Hizbollah's military activity that had formerly won the organization its legitimacy, prestige, and national consensus has forced it to alter its *modus operandi* through such stratagems as camouflaged, no-signature military activity. Parallel to this, Hizbollah is trying to find alternative anchors of legitimacy in order to continue its declared military activity. This attempt, only partially successful until now, has taken the form of anti-aircraft fire along the northern border, small-scale operations in the Shab'a Farms sector, and assistance to the Palestinian struggle.

This type of activity and especially the excessive caution that Hizbollah takes to preclude an Israeli strike indicate that the leaders of the Party of God are aware that Lebanese support of their operations is limited, and that public opinion in the country is decidedly against a destructive confrontation with Israel. The Hizbollah leadership sets much store by public opinion in its deliberations for or against a particular operation. At the end of January 2003, several days after Hizbollah's first operation in several months at Shab'a Farms, Na'im Qasim announced that his organization had no intention of turning the sector into an "arena of continuous fighting of no benefit," and that a periodic operation is sufficient "to give notice that the resistance continues." According to Qasim, neither quiet on the front nor a flare-up at Shab'a Farms should be expected, rather "perpetuation of the problem that Israel created."² Secretary-General Nasrallah also announced that, "Operations by the resistance organization are very carefully considered. Hizbollah has no interest in causing an explosion in the region or leading [it] toward escalation."³

If Hizbollah would want to heighten tensions along the border, it would do everything in its power to have Israel seen as the responsible party. Israel would be

faced with a dilemma: a disproportionate response could resurrect the Lebanese consensus in favor of Hizbollah. On the other hand, no response or a tepid one could erode Israel's deterrent power and indirectly encourage Hizbollah to test Israel repeatedly with the same dilemma.

History indicates that Israel's continued military presence on Lebanese soil furnished Hizbollah with a legitimate reason to expand its arsenal and develop its fighting prowess even when the Ta'if Agreement, which ended the Lebanese Civil War, stipulated the disarmament of all militias. In 1990, it was not inevitable or automatic that Hizbollah would deviate from the norm and remain the only militia fully armed, even if Israel retained its military presence in South Lebanon. Indeed, had Israel withdrawn from South Lebanon at the end of the Lebanese Civil War, Hizbollah would have found it much more difficult to preserve and build up its military capability. Instead, throughout the 1990s the Hizbollah fighter developed into a more experienced, better-skilled, and more sophisticated enemy.

The neutralization of Hizbollah's main arena of military activity resulted in the continuation and even enhancement of its "opening-up" rapprochement with the Lebanese environment. The organization's decision to publish a new and updated platform, which according to Na'im Qasim will be more moderate in its relations with the Lebanese Christians and Western countries like France, a country understood to oppose against Hizbollah's inclusion on the European Union's list of terror organizations, is no coincidence. The decision of Secretary-General Nasrallah to participate in the opening ceremony of the French-speaking states summit in Beirut, in the presence of the French President Jacques Chirac, and the publication of Na'im Qasim's book both demonstrate Hizbollah's high-profile attempts to open itself to its domestic environs and the international arena, and also perhaps to market a new image. Nasrallah's public appeal in late November 2002 to begin a nation-wide Lebanese dialogue is also part of this campaign.

The negation of the West, then, is not inherent in Hizbollah doctrine. In March 2003, on the eve of the American-led war in Iraq, Nasrallah stressed the need to acknowledge the growing anti-war demonstrations in the West and to avoid defining the Christians as "Crusaders." Afterwards, he even called for establishing a "Muslim-Christian alignment" to unite opponents of the war against Iraq.

Basically, Hizbollah is succumbing to the demands of reality. No organization, regardless of its ideological fervor, can survive unless it is able to respond and adapt itself to the dynamics of change around it. The more that an organization remains fixed in its conceptions and behavior patterns in the face of a changing reality, the greater the existential danger that it faces. Hizbollah is aware of this. In May 2000 a

reality change occurred on the Israeli-Lebanese border, and in an instant the arena was transformed from a dynamic, turbulent confrontation into an almost complete standstill, notwithstanding the underlying tensions. Life returned to normal on both sides of the border, and Hizbollah has had to maneuver and hammer out a compromise between ideology, imperatives, and interests.

The expression “the Great Satan” that Khomeini coined for the United States has not disappeared from Hizbollah leadership rhetoric. The fatal attacks against American servicemen stationed in Lebanon two decades ago were the practical application of this ideology. However, over the years Hizbollah has matured, and the difference between its image in the early 1980s and today reflects the fact that if once it could perpetrate the mass murder of French soldiers, then today the organization’s leader can attend a conference whose guest of honor is the president of France. Another example of change is the condemnation by the organization’s deputy secretary-general, in mid-November 2002, of three explosive charges – apparently planted by Palestinians – that detonated near American food chains in Lebanon on November 12, 2002 without causing any fatalities. Qasim, whose organization was responsible for the death of hundreds of American marines, was now prepared to state that it is better to struggle against the Americans by means of an economic boycott against their products, since “explosions like these serve Lebanon’s enemies by allowing them to claim there is no stability in Lebanon.”⁴

Overall, it seems that Hizbollah’s leaders have toned down their rhetoric in 2003, apparently because of American war preparations for the war in Iraq and the war itself, as well as the fear of an Israeli ploy to exploit the American campaign in order to attack Lebanon. If a few months earlier Israel voiced concern that Hizbollah was likely to take advantage of the war in Iraq to launch a strike in the north, then as time passed the organization has sought to allay this fear, mainly because the leadership realized that Hizbollah’s identification with Iraq would be counterproductive to its interests. “We do not support American aggression in Iraq but every one in the region knows of the historic animosity between Hizbollah and the Iraqi regime,” declared Nasrallah in February 2003, adding that “no connection exists between Hizbollah and the situation in Iraq.”⁵ Nonetheless, there is no doubt that Hizbollah has been forced to consider the ramifications of the United States-led war. This is particularly evidenced by the organization’s increased caution, both in its military activity and in its official pronouncements.

Since Israel’s withdrawal from Lebanon it has been evident that Hizbollah does not act spontaneously, rather calculates its operations carefully. Hence its reaction to the IAF strike in Syria on the night of October 4-5, 2003, which was the first attack of

its kind in three decades. The attack, which according to Israel targeted a Palestinian terrorist training camp outside of Damascus, came in response to the suicide bombing in Haifa's Maxim Restaurant, which killed twenty-two Israelis. Damascus-based Palestinian sources claimed that an abandoned camp of Ahmad Jibril's Popular Front – General Command had been hit.⁶ Hizbollah cast Israel's action as an attempt to destroy long-standing, accepted "rules of the game," warned Israel against a continuation of this attempt, and cautioned that Hizbollah would not sit quietly if Syria were attacked again:

We, or some of us, must not be scared and terrified. Let us see what Mr. Sharon wants and match his steps. Does he want to get crazy and lose his mind? If he wants to get crazy, there are people who will get crazy too. If he loses his mind, there are people who are ready to lose their mind too. If he were the only insane person in the region, your fears would be understood. His craziness and insanity will be treated with similar insanity and craziness.⁷

Thus, official Hizbollah reaction to the Israeli strike in Syria equated it with an attack on Lebanon⁸ – hinting at a potential Hizbollah response. In a speech in honor of International Jerusalem [al-Quds] Day, Nasrallah made it clear that Hizbollah provides a layer of defense for Syria against Israel:

Could this [Israeli] army enter southern Lebanon, Al-Biqā [Lebanon Valley], Jabal Lubnan [Mt. Lebanon], and the capital, Beirut, again? What stupid talk we hear sometimes! Who would believe such threats? Could this army enter Syria and Damascus, or Al-Biqā on its way to Homs and Aleppo? Would the road to Al-Biqā be a picnic for the Israeli Army on its way to Homs and Aleppo? This talk is just for local consumption. It would have been able to say such things before. Today, however, do not believe anything of the kind. This Israeli Army is too weak to do that.⁹

Of course no one can guarantee the continuation of the status quo between Israel and Hizbollah on the northern border – a dynamic that is in effect thanks to the policy of judicious brinkmanship by both parties, Israel's preventative interdictions, and in some cases Jordanian efforts. Despite this, Hizbollah's presumable covert no-signature activity contains the potential for disrupting the status quo. Israel too may decide to "collect on its debts" from Hizbollah. Until the present reality unravels, its

continuation will probably force Hizbollah to make compromises. Finally, although Hizbollah will continue to be counted among the destabilizing elements in the Middle East in the foreseeable future, its military potential will also be influenced, for in the long run, sustained quiet in the north will strengthen Hizbollah's civilian dimension and place a greater emphasis on its military power as a force designed primarily to protect Lebanon, rather than jeopardize it.